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Media Influence and Youth Migration Imaginaries Through Traditional and Social Platforms in the Context of Perception and Decision-Making

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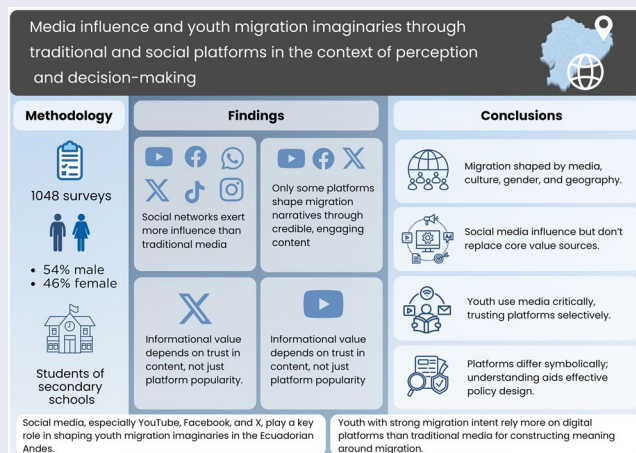
ABSTRACT

This quantitative, descriptive-correlational study investigates the influence of traditional and social media shape migration imaginaries among Andean Ecuadorian youth. Data were collected from 1,048 secondary students in 11 institutions across three provinces using a structured questionnaire. Among several platforms, YouTube, Facebook, and X showed the strongest influence on perceptions of structural causes, benefits, and sociocultural-economic challenges, while traditional media had marginal effects. Findings underscore the strategic role of digital ecosystems in shaping migration-related decision-making and underscore the need for culturally grounded communication strategies and media literacy initiatives in high-mobility contexts.

KEYWORDS

Migratory imaginary; perception of migration; youth migration; social media; media literacy

GRAPHICAL ABSTRACT



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Youth migration and media influence in Ecuador

Currently, Ecuador is undergoing a spiral of violence that positions it among the countries with the highest homicide rates in the region, registering 38.8 violent deaths per 100,000 inhabitants (Ecuadoriano de Crimen Organizado, 2024). This critical situation is compounded by a multitude of economic, social, and political factors (Macías Ponce et al., 2024), which underscore the pressing need to improve the quality of life for its citizens (Organización Internacional para las Migraciones, 2023), resulting in increased mobility of Ecuadorians seeking opportunities abroad. Indeed, the Organización Internacional para las Migraciones (2024) reported that 71% of Ecuadorians express a concrete intention to migrate to a specific destination.

Young Ecuadorians experience migration as a phenomenon that is both current and intimately connected to their personal realities. Litardo and Villacís (2024) point out that 30.8% of Ecuadorians with migration plans belong to the youth demographic, specifically individuals aged 18 to 29. Thus, the intention to migrate among young people is driven primarily by two key factors: the aspiration to improve their financial situation in order to remit funds to their families in Ecuador, and the pursuit of broader access to essential services such as education and healthcare (Torres-Toukoudidis et al., 2024).

Prospective young migrants navigate a diverse media ecosystem that shapes their perceptions of migration and informs decision-making. Young people perceive social media platforms as valuable tools for evaluating preferred migration destinations, potential integration experiences, and prevailing public opinion concerning cultural adaptation and acceptance (Righi, 2019), contributing to the formation of migration imaginaries, the collective representations through which migration is imagined, discussed, and emotionally experienced in digital environments (Seuferling & Leurs, 2021). Traditional media are perceived to influence decisions to emigrate or elicit concerns about rejection, racism, and misinformation (Gómez-Vicario et al., 2024), whereas social media are primarily associated with shaping intentions, information gathering, and engagement with migration narratives (Ihejirika & Krtalic, 2021; Kocatepe et al., 2023).

Despite the growing body of literature examining the relationship between media ecosystems and migration-related perceptions among youth, existing studies show fragmented and often contradictory findings. Prior research indicates that young migrants use social media to gather information and shape expectations during early migration decision-making (Ihejirika & Krtalic, 2021; Righi, 2019), while other studies emphasize that traditional media exert a stronger influence on emigration decisions

(Kocatepe et al., 2023) or reinforce negative emotions such as fear, rejection, and misinformation (Gómez-Vicario et al., 2024). Moreover, although the symbolic construction of migration has been examined in contexts such as Europe, North America, and New Zealand, no studies have yet analyzed how these dynamics unfold among adolescents in Ecuador—a country currently experiencing accelerated out-migration and severe socio-political instability. This absence is critical, as Latin American youth engage with a hybrid media environment in ways that differ from those documented in Global North populations, particularly in terms of credibility assessment, informational needs, and media literacy (Eberl et al., 2018). In hybrid media ecologies, young audiences combine traditional information sources with algorithmically curated social media platforms, which requires them to assess credibility through heuristic and socially mediated cues rather than relying exclusively on institutional authority (Metzger et al., 2010). Such credibility judgments are often shaped by cognitive shortcuts, perceived expertise, and social endorsement. Moreover, contemporary media literacy research highlights that youth engagement with social media involves varying degrees of skepticism and evaluative competence, which influence how information is interpreted and accepted in digital environments (Vraga & Tully, 2021). Thus, the research gap lies in the lack of empirical evidence about how Ecuadorian adolescents integrate traditional and social media cues to construct migration imaginaries and how perceived credibility and informational needs mediate this process. Addressing this gap is essential for understanding youth migration intentions in high-mobility Andean contexts and for informing communication strategies and public policies aligned with local digital cultures, emerging a clear need to examine the migratory behaviors of Ecuadorian youth in greater depth, guided by the following research questions:

RQ1: How do traditional media influence the shaping of social perceptions of migration?

RQ2: What role does social media play in shaping perceptions of migration?

RQ3: To what extent do perceived credibility and media literacy mediate the relationship between media consumption and attitudes toward migration?

Through these inquiries, this study aims to contribute to the understanding of how media influence is perceived in the construction of migration imaginaries and its broader implications, particularly among young people, the social group most vulnerable to the current dynamics of migration. The analysis focuses on critical aspects such as information needs, the types of social media used, and the credibility and influence attributed to these platforms.

Theoretical framework

Media narratives and youth migration

The present study adds to the literature by extending established media effects frameworks to a hybrid ecosystem of traditional and digital media. Also, to strengthen the theoretical fit of the study, it is necessary to clarify the relevance of Cultivation Theory and Framing Theory within the analyzed media and migration dynamics. Cultivation Theory is incorporated by examining how sustained exposure to migration-related content across traditional and digital media environments contributes to the gradual consolidation of perceptions, expectations and imaginaries among Ecuadorian adolescents. This approach extends the classical television-centred formulation proposed by Morgan et al. (2018) toward a hybrid and algorithmically mediated landscape in which social media amplify selective narratives concerning opportunities, risks and socioeconomic mobility. On the other hand, Framing Theory provides a complementary interpretive lens for understanding the way representational logics shape the meanings attributed to migration. In line with Entman (1993), frames determine the salience of specific aspects of the phenomenon, whether presented as a threat, as social mobility or as a structural response to precarity. This study highlights how such frames vary between traditional media and participatory digital environments. By showing that adolescents negotiate these discourses according to their informational needs, their evaluations of source credibility and the communicative affordances of each platform, demonstrating that media effects are neither linear nor uniform. Its theoretical contribution lies in integrating cultivation and framing processes within a Latin American adolescent context, which remains insufficiently explored in the literature, and in displaying that these mechanisms are mediated by the ways young people assess credibility and engage selectively with different media.

First, the Cultivation Theory is rescued, which was traditionally applied to the television medium, in order to show the enduring influence of exposure to migration narratives in multiplatform contexts. The findings, along with Morgan et al. (2018), indicate that media repetitions and themed presentation shape stereotype perceptions, although moderated by the type of media consumed.

Secondly, the study refers to framing, i.e. how media representation of migration (as threat, criminality or victimisation) influences social attitudes. According to Entman (1993), frames select and emphasize certain aspects of reality and shape how the public interprets complex phenomena. In our case, differences stand out between traditional media frames and those on social platforms.

The third contribution of this article to credibility and media literacy studies is that the analysis shows that perceived credibility works as a cognitive filter that modulates the acceptance or questioning of migration narratives. This finding talks to studies that record the relevance of credibility in the critical reception of digital content (Vraga & Tully, 2021). Similarly, by locating the analysis in young Latin Americans, the study expands the geographical scope of the literature, which has been almost exclusively European and North American (Eberl et al., 2018). The integration of cultivation, framing, and media literacy provides a theoretical framework that allows to understand how perceptions about migration articulate in mediated societies.

Traditional and digital media function as active agents in the construction of meaning surrounding youth migration, transcending their informational role to become arenas of symbolic contestation. In this study, the media refers to both traditional media (television, radio and print media) and digital/social media, which allow for interactivity and collaborative production of content. This differentiation is crucial, as the first tend to configure collective perceptions through centralized narratives, while the second generates a context for the rapid, fragmented, and personalized circulation of information (Livingstone, 2004; Ren et al., 2024). Traditional media refers to channels of mass communication that existed prior to the rise of the Internet and Web 2.0; these include newspapers (print), magazines, radio, and broadcast television. Social media denotes web-based platforms and applications built on the technological and ideological foundations of Web 2.0 that enable users to create, share, and disseminate user-generated content, and to interact and collaborate in virtual networks (Fotopoulos, 2023).

Media narratives not only reflect realities but also construct them through interpretive frames that oscillate between hope and risk. As Hinck et al. (2023) emphasize, journalistic coverage and media discourses are frequently shaped by political and economic agendas, resulting in a multiplicity of dichotomous representations. On one hand, migration is idealized as a mechanism for social mobility. According to Koser (2010), contemporary migration literature differentiates between regular migration (which takes place with the consent of the states concerned) and irregular migration (which happens in the absence of or loss of such consent). We can't understand irregularity as an inherent condition. It is rather a socio-legal and political construct depending on existing normative frameworks (Düvell, 2011). Scholars identify the existence of a regularity-irregularity continuum, with migrants potentially progressing between statuses depending on their administrative situation. Recent research suggests that the drivers of irregular migration may differ from regular migration and

thus warrant a differentiated analytical treatment (Dennison, 2022). On the other hand, emphasis is placed on its dangers, such as labor exploitation and xenophobia. Another dichotomy involves the shaping of expectations among potential migrants, who are portrayed either as vulnerable victims or economic opportunists (Chouliaraki, 2020), thereby oversimplifying the structural causes of youth human mobility.

These dualities become more pronounced when contrasting traditional and digital media. Regarding traditional outlets, Stefoni and Brito (2019) observe that television and print media tend to reproduce institutional discourses that reinforce classist and racial stereotypes. In contrast, platforms such as Instagram, YouTube, and TikTok democratize narrative production through first-person migrant testimonies (Jaramillo-Dent & Pérez-Rodríguez, 2021; Lara & Gerstner, 2016). Nevertheless, as Couldry (2012) argues, this apparent digital diversity and horizontality may fragment understanding of the phenomenon, since algorithmic logics prioritize emotionally viral content over rigorous analysis. This reinforces cultural biases, such as equating migration with economic success in the Global North (Mahmoudi, 2025).

While media serve to inform, they also cognitively frame motivations for migration. Leurs and Smets (2018) point out that algorithms on platforms like Instagram tend to prioritize content that links migration to consumption, reinforcing the notion that foreign destinations guarantee material well-being. A study by Dekker and Engbersen (2014) on migrant communities in the Netherlands revealed that 58% of viral videos on social media associated migration with luxury consumption, while omitting references to legal or labor-related hardships. According to Siapera and Veikou (2013), this aestheticization of the migratory experience is consistent with neoliberal logics that individualize risk and place responsibility for success or failure on the subjects themselves.

The credibility of media sources emerges as a critical axis in the construction of migratory imaginaries. While governmental institutions are often perceived by youth as distant or disconnected, social media testimonies gain authority due to their emotional immediacy. However, this dynamic reveal significant fissures. Citton (2017) argues that distrust in traditional media does not necessarily entail a critical evaluation of digital sources, but rather an uncritical transfer of credibility to content that resonates emotionally. For example, Tandoc, (2019) identified that Facebook posts on migration frequently contained misleading information but were widely shared due to their sentimental tone (Zarzycka, 2018). This paradox reveals that credibility is not solely based on factual accuracy, but also on the capacity of content to activate collective emotions, regardless of its veracity, eliciting sentiments of hope or fear (Waisbord, 2018).

Informational needs, media credibility, and digital vulnerabilities in youth migration

The relationship between migration, media credibility and media literacy is a central axis for understanding how social perceptions are constructed. The media discourse on migration refers to the news reporting on migrants and the media coverage of migration issues at large. The credibility of the sources is understood as the perception of reliability and truthfulness of the issuer, which acts as a cognitive filter that regulates the acceptance or questioning of such discourses (Metzger et al., 2010). In this sense, media literacy provides recipients with critical competences to interpret, evaluate, and contextualize messages, reducing susceptibility to stereotypes and misinformation (Mihailidis & Viotty, 2017). In this way, a robust analytical framework for the studied perceptions is proposed, namely migration-credibility-media literacy.

Contemporary youth migration is marked by its hyperconnected nature. The media construction of youth migration is shaped by a combination of factors, including informational needs, media platform usage, perceived credibility of these sources, and the misinformative role of certain content. Visual platforms such as Instagram and TikTok function as symbolic spaces where migration is represented and imagined. Research by Witteborn (2020) shows that migrants use stories and reels to negotiate transnational identities, although these narratives are often edited according to algorithmic logics that prioritize spectacle over complexity (Chua et al., 2021).

The centrality of social media lies in its ability to meet specific informational needs that are often neglected by institutional actors and traditional mass media. In Ecuador, for instance, TikTok emerged in 2024 as the fastest-growing social media platform, reaching 14.26 million accounts and showing a 19.7% increase in just one year (Del Alcázar Ponce, 2024). This growth is largely attributed to a 25% increase in users aged 18 to 24, the primary demographic focus of this study. In contrast, Facebook (13.6M) and Instagram (6.8M) experienced a marked decline in adolescent users aged 13 to 17, with Facebook losing 85.7% in this age group.

While academic literature has primarily focused on the role of platforms like YouTube, Facebook and X in the circulation of migratory narratives (Bleich et al., 2018; Valenzuela et al., 2012), we acknowledge that the digital ecosystem is much more expansive. In the Latin American case, other networks such as Instagram, LinkedIn, Telegram, TikTok and WhatsApp perform central roles in the construction of perceptions and in the dissemination of informative and disinformative content. However, their lesser representation in the specialized literature reflects both the novelty of their impact and the methodological difficulty in capturing their dynamics (Mascheroni & Ólafsson, 2016).

Prospective young migrants often seek situated, practical information: visa costs, real wages in informal sectors, or strategies to bypass border controls (Collins, 2018). Media credibility in the migration context is constructed largely through what Partenio (2011) terms “experiential authority,” the idea that only those who have migrated can provide valid advice. However, this logic overlooks the fact that many influencers monetize their narratives, often concealing systemic barriers or promoting fraudulent legal services (Nevárez, 2021). While social media empowers users with immediate access to information, its commercial architecture simultaneously fosters misinformation (Magallón-Rosa, 2021). Bandiera and Daniel (2024) explain that misinformation spreads more rapidly when embedded in compelling personal stories, such as fake job offers propagated by traffickers. Moreover, the digital divide exacerbates existing inequalities: rural youth with limited internet access rely on radio or television messages, which often omit critical details about migration requirements (Borkert et al., 2018).

Within this media ecosystem, youth migration in Latin America and the Caribbean emerges as a complex phenomenon driven by factors such as unemployment, political instability, and the pursuit of better opportunities (Armijos-Orellana et al., 2025). Although young migrants often pursue personal goals and achievements, they face vulnerabilities, particularly in intraregional migration, including disadvantages in education and employment (Martínez Pizarro, 2000). The lack of legal recognition of young immigrants, as observed in Mexico, can significantly impact human rights and public policy (Velasco Rentería, 2023). In Chile, youth migration has been studied from the perspectives of both Chilean and immigrant youth, revealing issues of discrimination and otherness (Aravena Reyes & Alt Álvarez, 2012).

In Ecuador, these dynamics take on critical dimensions due to its migration history. Following the banking crisis of 1999 and dollarization in 2000, approximately 10% of the population emigrated to Spain and the United States (Jokisch & Kyle, 2005), establishing transnational networks that today’s youth reengage through digital platforms. These dynamics are gaining urgency amid the resurgence of post-pandemic migratory flows and an ongoing economic crisis. Ecuador has alternated between being a country of emigration and immigration, with waves directed toward Spain between 2000 and 2008 (de Lera & Pérez-Caramés, 2015) and inflows from Venezuela between 2015 and 2019 (Molina-Ramón et al., 2024), leaving systematized lessons for new generations, particularly in social and communicational domains.

In the social sphere, there is clear evidence that rural Ecuadorian youth harbor strong aspirations to migrate to urban centers in search of better

economic and educational opportunities, rather than engaging in agriculture (Eche-Enríquez & Vivas-Vivas, 2022). Similarly, migration patterns between Ecuador and Spain have shifted, with a notable increase in Ecuadorian youth migrating to pursue higher education (Vega Solís et al., 2016). Ultimately, the diversification of mobility among Ecuadorian youth is evident worldwide (Eguiguren, 2017), contributing to the growth of the four largest Ecuadorian migrant communities: the United States (418k), Spain (417k), Italy (83k), and Chile (42k), as well as neighboring countries like Colombia (19k) and Peru (13k) (Jokisch, 2023).

From a communication standpoint, Litardo and Villacís (2024) assert that social media platforms shape aspirational narratives that contribute to the construction of migration imaginaries, support networks, facilitation mechanisms, and perceptions of risk and expectation.

Given this context, the present study is crucial for unraveling the logics at the intersection of under-researched areas such as youth migration, media credibility, and informational needs. The hypotheses proposed herein, ranging from the predominant influence of social media to its role in shaping migration imaginaries, may illuminate the gaps between public policy, education, and everyday information practices. Addressing these gaps is essential to prevent hyperconnectivity from reproducing new forms of vulnerability, and instead, to transform digital networks into authentic tools of autonomy for a generation navigating between local precarity and global illusions.

Methodology

This study adopts a descriptive and correlational approach, with the general objective of analyzing the perceived influence of traditional media and, in particular, social media on young people's perceptions of migration in Ecuador's Andean region. In order to address this aim, the following specific hypotheses were proposed:

H1: Higher perceived negative framing of migrants in traditional media is associated with greater internalization of stereotypes.

H2: More frequent use of social media is associated with more polarized views of migration.

H3: People who are media literate are better able to understand how the media could affect their perception. They will not see the media as gospel truth. Thus, the stereotypical frames of the media will have less impact on them.

H4: Higher perceived platform credibility plays a significant role in shaping young people's attitudes and perceptions in Ecuador's Andean region concerning the causes, challenges, and benefits of migration.

Methods and data collection

To test these hypotheses, a quantitative research design was adopted. This design aimed at examining the relationships between variables using a structured questionnaire administered to students. The survey comprises 21 questions, distributed as follows: 6 sociodemographic items, 3 items addressing migration imaginaries, 3 items concerning the causes of migration, 3 items on the perceived impact of migration, and 6 items addressing platform usage, perceived credibility, and perceived influence of social media and traditional media.

The survey items were validated using established criteria drawn from Sotomayor et al. (2019) for general questions; Sánchez-Santacruz (2022) and Armijos-Orellana (2025) for the causes of migration; for the impact of migration; and Heidenreich et al. (2020), Pisarevskaya et al. (2020), and Wright et al. (2021) concerning the media's role. Based on these references, three variables were established to assess the migration imaginary: the current state of migration (dichotomous), intention to migrate (ternary), and the perceived probability of migrating to another country (measured on a five-point Likert scale). Regarding the causes of migration, three categories were defined: economic, social, and political. Each included specific options evaluated by respondents according to their perceived importance using a five-point scale: not important, slightly important, moderately important, important, and very important. The same evaluative system was applied to the questions on the perceived impact of migration (including perceived impact, challenges, and benefits). In contrast, for the media's role, two dichotomous questions and four multivariate items were designed to capture the types of social media platforms used, as well as the perceived influence and credibility of each platform as reported by respondents, reflecting subjective perceptions rather than measured behavioral or attitudinal effects. The study considered a comprehensive range of social media platforms widely used by Ecuadorian youth, including Facebook, YouTube, X (formerly Twitter), Instagram, WhatsApp, TikTok, LinkedIn, and Telegram. These platforms were selected based on their prevalence in the regional digital ecosystem (Del Alcázar Ponce, 2024, Mascheroni & Ólafsson, 2016) and their relevance to migration-related information exchange and discourse, as well as to participants perceived influence (Litardo & Villacís, 2024; Zarzycka, 2018).

The survey was conducted anonymously on a non-probabilistic convenience sample, yielding 1,048 responses from students ($M = 567$; $F = 481$) in the final three years of secondary education (1st year of bachillerato = 342; 2nd year = 346; 3rd year = 360) from 11 educational institutions located in the Andean region of Ecuador. Students in these grades typically fall within the age range of 15 to 18 years. Specifically, the cities of Azogues,

Cuenca, and Quito, situated in the provinces of Cañar, Azuay, and Pichincha respectively, were selected due to their significance within the national migratory landscape (El Universo, 2023). Prior to implementation of the survey, formal authorization was obtained from Zonal Coordination 6 of the Ecuadorian Ministry of Education and by the participating secondary schools. The process of informing parents and legal representatives, as well as collecting their consent, was facilitated directly by the educational institutions. Written informed consent was obtained from all legal representatives of the respondents before data collection began.

In this study, the gender variable was treated as binary, distinguishing between male and female participants, based on their self-reported identification. Gender was understood as a social construct encompassing the roles, behaviors, and identities of women and men, situated within specific cultural and historical contexts. Although gender is conceptually distinct from sex, understood as a set of biological characteristics typically assigned at birth, this research did not collect disaggregated data on assigned sex or gender identity. Consequently, the term 'gender' may implicitly overlap with both constructs in the interpretation of the results.

Data collection was carried out between 18 November 2023 and 28 April 2024 by visiting each of the authorized educational institutions. The survey was administered digitally through institutional computers, using a Google Forms questionnaire. The average completion time ranged between 7 and 20 minutes.

Data analysis

The data were processed using R software (version 4.4.1), employing descriptive statistics, correlation analyses, and correspondence analyses, selected according to the typology of each variable. Descriptive graphical analyses were presented using pie charts to visualize the distribution of key categorical variables. These visualizations allowed for the identification of response proportions and demographic characteristics of the participants, offering an initial overview of the data structure.

To assess associations between categorical variables, chi-square tests were employed, with accuracy enhanced via Monte Carlo simulations. This methodological approach facilitated the robust handling and analysis of sparse data, thereby ensuring the reliability of the results. Furthermore, the Benjamini-Hochberg (BH) correction was applied to control the false discovery rate and to mitigate the risk of Type I errors, which could arise due to increased significance levels introduced by Monte Carlo procedures.

Multiple Correspondence Analysis (MCA) was subsequently used to explore relationships among multiple categorical variables. By identifying latent structures within the dataset, the analysis revealed patterns in up

to two dimensions, with the perceived influence of social media treated as the primary response variable. Nevertheless, due to pronounced asymmetries in the distribution of responses, clear group separations were not always observable. Despite this, MCA yielded valuable insights into the complex interrelations among variables and the broader data structure.

The robustness and validity of the data were supported by ensuring an expected frequency of at least five observations per cell in the chi-square contingency tables, as values below this threshold may lead to inaccuracies due to deviation from the theoretical chi-square distribution. Monte Carlo simulations further reinforced the validity of these tests by maintaining this minimum threshold, thereby preventing disproportionate influence from low-frequency values. By running numerous random simulations, this approach allowed for more precise probabilistic estimations in contexts where traditional chi-square testing may be unreliable.

In addition, Cramér's V coefficient was employed to measure the strength of association between categorical variables, thereby complementing the findings obtained through chi-square tests and Monte Carlo simulations. This statistic quantifies the degree of association, with values ranging from 0 (no association) to 1 (perfect association). The application of the BH correction also ensured that adjusted p -values reduced the likelihood of falsely significant associations. The combined use of descriptive graphical analyses, chi-square tests with Monte Carlo simulations, and MCA enabled a nuanced and comprehensive understanding of the factors influencing the intention to migrate.

The methodological design of this study thus provides a rigorous foundation for exploring the influence of the media, particularly social media platforms, on young people's perceptions of migration within the Andean region of Ecuador.

Results

Perceptions of media influence on migration imaginaries from traditional to social media

The survey results offer insightful evidence regarding how young people from the three selected Andean provinces of Ecuador perceive migration. Notably, 96% of respondents consider migration to be a current and relevant phenomenon. Furthermore, 44% of the surveyed youth expressed a desire to migrate, while 42% regard migration as a viable option for their near future. The most preferred destination countries include the United States (58.6%), Spain (45%), and Italy (42.5%). Although most respondents (53%) perceive the impact of migration on the host countries as negative, this perception does not appear to diminish their intention to emigrate.

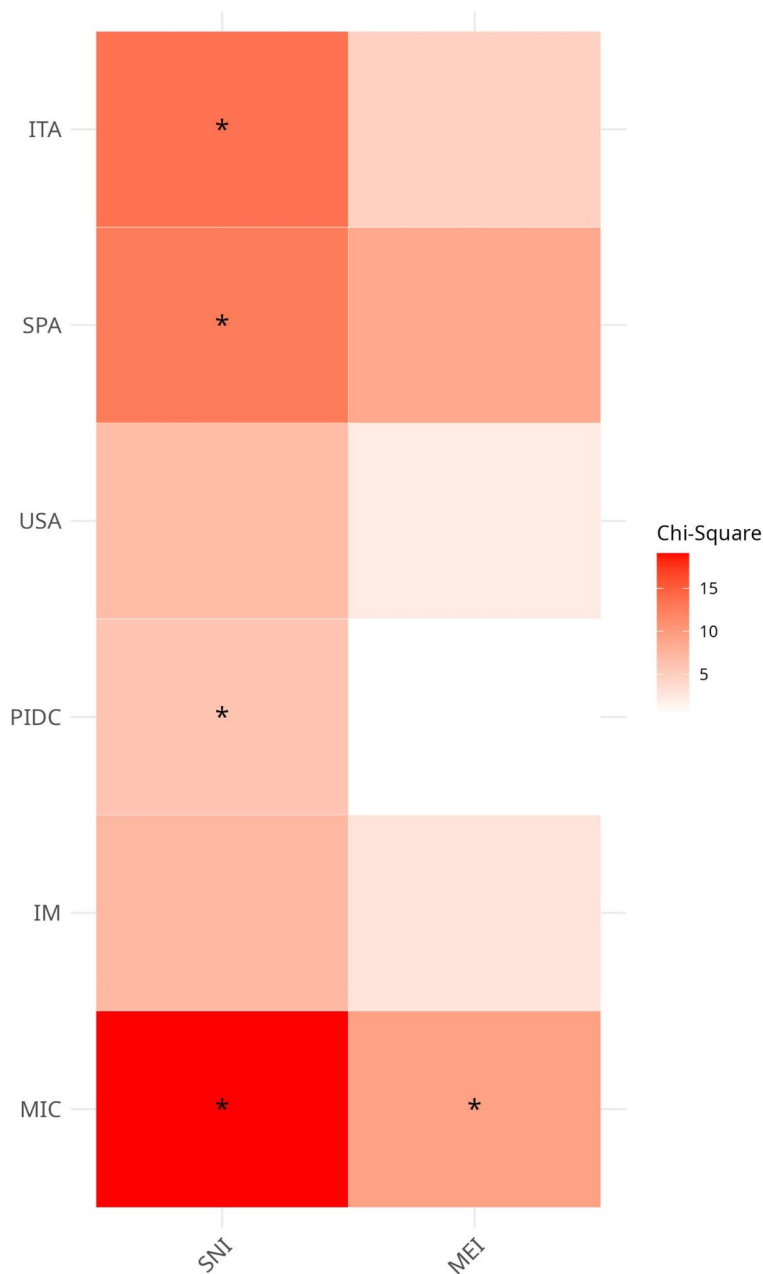


Figure 1. Association between migration perceptions and the influence attributed to traditional media and social networks.
Note: SNI: social networks influence, MEI: traditional media influence; ITA: migration probability to Italy, SPA: migration probability to Spain, USA: migration probability to USA, PIDC: perceived impact on destination country, IM: intention to migrate, MIC: migration is currently.

A chi-square analysis was employed to assess the statistical association between the perceived influence of traditional and social media on migratory imaginaries and variables such as current status, intention to migrate, and perceived probability of migrating to another country (Figure 1). The

results reveal statistically significant relationships ($p < 0.05$) between these variables (see [Supplementary Tables S1](#) and [S2](#)). In particular, the association between perceptions of social media influence and the contemporaneity of migration as a phenomenon is stronger ($p = 0.006$) than that associated with traditional media ($p = 0.03$). Notably, traditional media influence was not significantly associated with either the intention or the perceived probability of migration, nor with perceptions of the impact of migration on destination countries ($p > 0.05$).

By creating pie charts ([Figure 2](#)), it becomes evident that perceptions of the contemporaneity of migration (MIC) and its impact on destination countries (PIDC) are shaped by traditional media exposure.

Among respondents who perceive migration as a current issue, 89% attribute influence on social media on their migratory imaginaries, whereas 91% identify traditional media (MEI) as exerting such influence. Conversely, a lower proportion of individuals who do not regard migration as a contemporary phenomenon acknowledge media influence: 76% do not perceive traditional media as shaping their migratory imaginaries, compared to 67% who do not attribute such influence on social media.

Similar results were observed regarding the relationship between the perception of the impact of migration on the destination country (PIDC) and the influence attributed to social networks (SNI). Respondents who perceive the impact as positive (85%) assign less weight to this influence than those who regard it as negative (90%). However, although the relationship is statistically significant, Cramér's V indicates that the strength of the association is weak ($V < 0.20$).

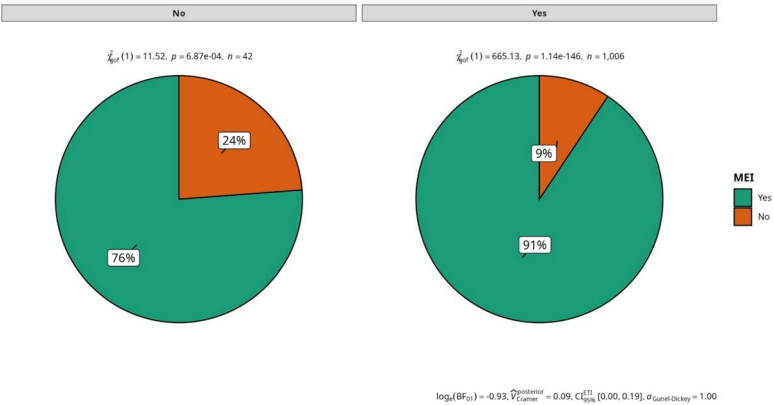
To explore the relationships among various categorical variables and to identify underlying patterns, Multiple Correspondence Analyses (MCA) were conducted. This analytical approach facilitates the visualization of significant associations and the latent structure of binary responses concerning the relationship between the influence attributed to social networks and the media, the current salience of the migration phenomenon, and the perceived impact on the destination country ([Figure 3](#)).

For the MCA, the variable "likelihood of migrating to another country" was analyzed by focusing exclusively on Spain and Italy as potential destinations, given that these countries show significant associations with the influence of social networks ([Figure 3](#)). Including other migration destinations did not contribute to data differentiation and hindered the visual interpretation of the emerging patterns.

The analysis reveals that Dimensions One and Two account for 14.9% and 13.2% of the variance, respectively ([Figure 4](#)), representing a relative portion of the total variance that enables the identification of meaningful trends and patterns concerning the relationships among the variables under

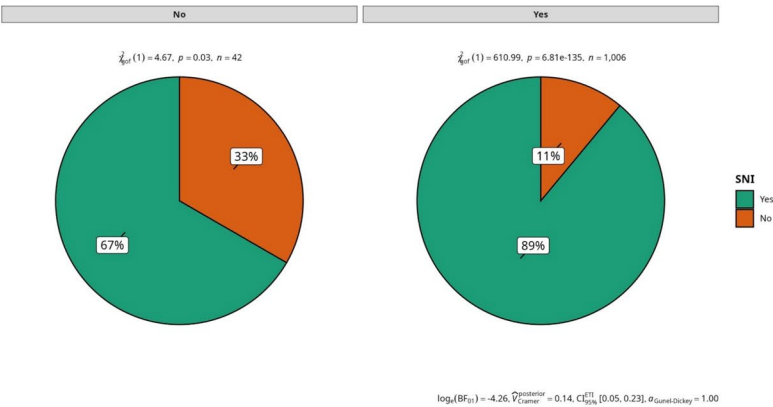
MEI con MIC

$\chi^2_{\text{Pearson}}(1) = 9.44, p = 2.13\text{e-}03, \hat{V}_{\text{Cramer}} = 0.09, \text{CI}_{95\%} [0.01, 0.15], n_{\text{obs}} = 1,048$



SNI con MIC

$\chi^2_{\text{Pearson}}(1) = 19.08, p = 1.25\text{e-}05, \hat{V}_{\text{Cramer}} = 0.13, \text{CI}_{95\%} [0.07, 0.19], n_{\text{obs}} = 1,048$



SNI con PIDC

$\chi^2_{\text{Pearson}}(1) = 6.01, p = 0.01, \hat{V}_{\text{Cramer}} = 0.07, \text{CI}_{95\%} [0.00, 0.13], n_{\text{obs}} = 1,048$

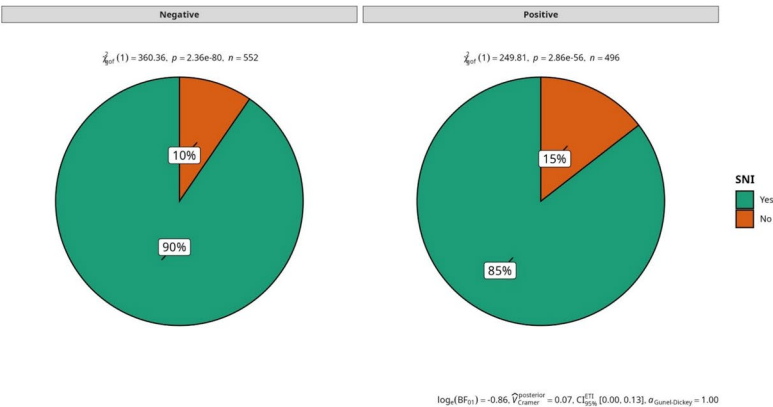


Figure 2. The influence of traditional and social media influence on the perception of the current status of migration and its impact on the host country.
Note: SNI: social networks influence, MEI: traditional media influence, PIDC: perceived impact on destination country, MIC: migration is currently.

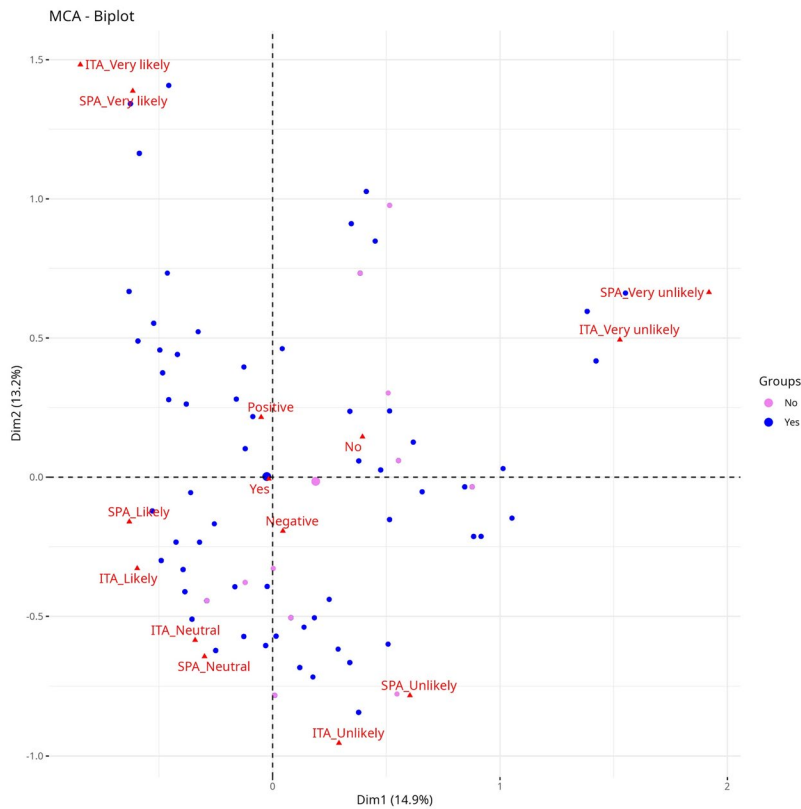


Figure 3. Multiple correspondence analysis on social network influence concerning migration vision by the probability to emigrate.

Note: GROUPS. Yes: Social networks influence young people's perception of migration, No: Social networks don't influence young people's perception of migration; ITA: migration probability to Italy, SPA: migration probability to Spain, Positive: perceived impact of migration on destination country is positive, Negative: perceived impact of migration on destination country is negative, Yes: migration is currently, No: migration is not currently.

examination. This is particularly valuable given the study's exploratory nature, which investigates Ecuadorian adolescents' perceptions and the role of traditional and social media in the migration phenomenon.

The Multiple Correspondence Analysis (MCA) results indicate that young people from the Andean region of Ecuador perceive social media as influential in shaping their migratory imaginaries and perceived impacts, particularly regarding the likelihood of migrating to Spain and Italy.

The significance attributed to the likelihood of migrating to these two European countries and the limited importance ascribed to the same set of factors contribute to the differentiation among individuals, as illustrated in the contribution graph (Figure 4). Specifically, higher levels of perceived probability of migrating to either of these countries are associated with the influence attributed to social media in constructing imaginaries around migration, and their perceived positive impact in the destination country.

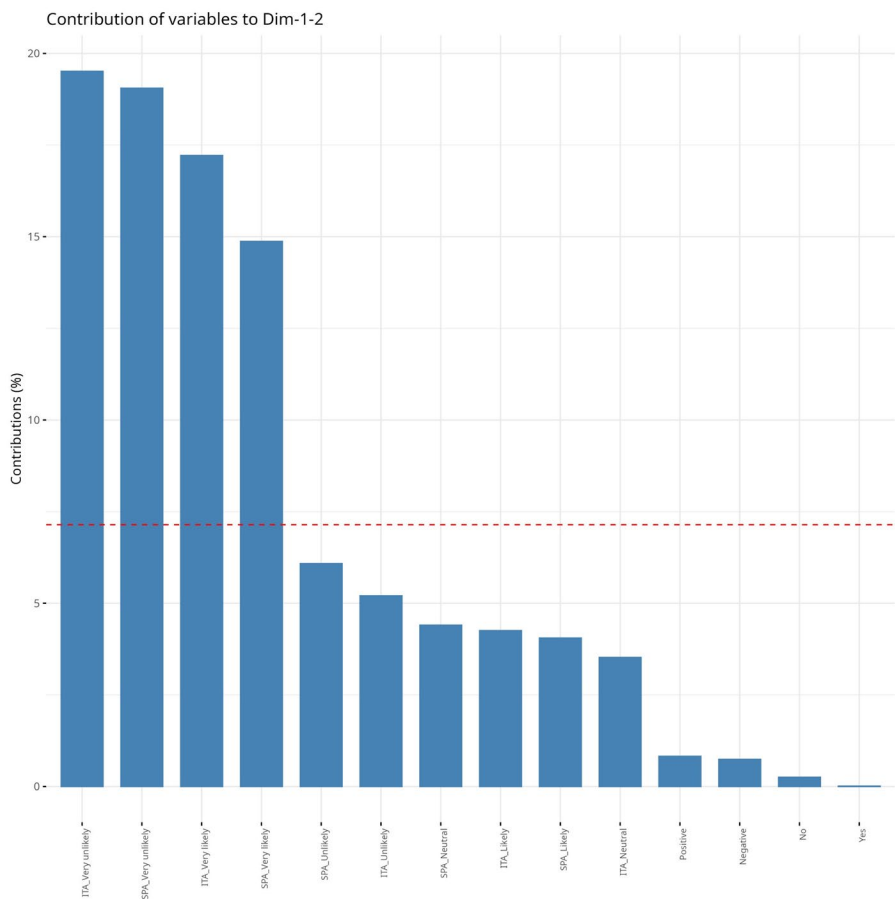


Figure 4. Contribution to dimensions 1 and 2 in MCA analysis on social network influence in Figure 3.

Note: GROUPS. ITA: migration probability to Italy, SPA: migration probability to Spain, Positive: perceived impact of migration on destination country is positive, Negative: perceived impact of migration on destination country is negative, Yes: migration is currently, No: migration is not currently.

The role of social media in migration intentions and probabilities

The most widely used social media platforms among young people in Ecuador’s Andean region are WhatsApp (95.8%), Instagram (90%), TikTok (87.5%), and YouTube (71.3%), followed at a greater distance by Facebook (53.4%), considering only those platforms mentioned by over half of respondents. However, the platforms considered most suitable for initiating the migration process are Instagram (61.9%), Facebook (61.5%), and TikTok (58.5%). The most credible platforms regarding migration-related information are Facebook (55%) and X (formerly Twitter) (44%), followed closely by TikTok (35.6%), YouTube (35.4%), and Instagram (33%). Despite being the most used service, WhatsApp is perceived as credible by only 12.8% of respondents and as helpful in starting the migration process by 31.7%.

Regarding gender, men lead in the volume of social media platforms used, the degree of credibility attributed to them, and the extent of informational needs regarding migration. Although the sample is not perfectly balanced (54% of respondents identify as male), this proportion is exceeded in nearly all variables that show significant relationships with gender, except for the credibility attributed to Facebook, which is perceived equally by both genders. Among YouTube users, 58% are male, and male usage surpasses the 60% threshold for X (63%), Telegram (68%), and LinkedIn (94%), although the latter two platforms are used by only 20% and 1.53% of the sample, respectively.

Among the four most-used platforms, and with the province of Pichincha leading in all categories, YouTube and Instagram stand out as the least disregarded platforms by young people from this province (only 18% and 19%, respectively, do not use them). Instagram and TikTok are distributed almost proportionally among the three provinces, although Azuay exhibits the highest youth rejection of TikTok (48%), YouTube, and Instagram (51%).

The chi-square analysis reveals a scarcity of statistically significant associations between the variables defining the role of social media in migration and the variables of intention and probability of migrating. Significant associations are recorded only between the likelihood of migrating to Spain and using YouTube ($p=0.046$), and TikTok as a platform used at the beginning of the migration process ($p=0.034$). There is also a significant ($p=0.034$) but weak (Cramer's $V=0.08$) association between the use of Instagram and the probability of migrating to Italy. Nonetheless, those considering migration to this country do not hold Instagram in high regard, with proportions exceeding 58% across all categories indicating insufficient consideration.

Informational needs on migration and the role of social media

Youth in Ecuador's Andean region exhibit an informational demand concerning migration that exceeds the supply available through traditional media and digital platforms. Specifically, 39% express a desire to learn about migrants' life stories (ITNM Statistical data), 33% seek statistical data on migration (ITNM Life history), and 26% request information to better understand and analyze existing migration policies (ITNM Migration policy) regarding both national circumstances and destination countries.

The application of chi-square analysis reveals several associations between informational needs regarding migration, sociodemographic variables, and the role of traditional and social media in the migration process, particularly social media. A significant association exists between young people's need for information on migration and their province of residence (PRO) and the type of secondary educational institution (INST) they attend. Specifically, the need to obtain statistical data on migration shows significant associations with

province ($p=0.002$), type of institution ($p=0.007$), and gender ($p=0.018$), with males (58%) demonstrating greater interest in this type of information. Similarly, the province of residence and the type of institution are significantly associated with the need to understand migration policies ($p=0.002$). Youth from Pichincha are more likely to seek information on migration policies (44%) and statistical data (40%) than their peers from Azuay and Cañar. Students from church-affiliated institutions (fiscomisionales) are those most likely to express a need for information on migration policies (45%) and statistical data (38%), in higher proportions than their peers in private ($>30\%$) and public ($<30\%$) schools. However, despite the significance of these relationships, the Cramer's V coefficient ($V<0.30$) indicates that the strength of these associations is moderate.

The most frequently reported informational need, learning about migrants' life stories, does not show any statistically significant association with sociodemographic variables, suggesting a generalized interest in this topic.

The heat map derived from the chi-square analysis reveals the associations between informational needs and social media's role in migration (Figure 5). The use of YouTube (SNU_YouTube) and X (SNU_X) is significantly associated with the need for information regarding migrants' life histories ($p=0.005$) and migration policies ($p=0.005$). However, the latter need decreases with X ($p=0.021$).

The influence of social media on perceptions of migration diminishes when examining the relationships between the informational needs of young people in the Andean region of Ecuador and the types of social media platforms used to seek information at the onset of the migration process (see Supplementary Tables S3 and S4). Except for significant associations between the use of Instagram (SNSM_Instagram) and the need for information about migration policies ($p=0.005$), and between the use of X (SNSM_X) and the need to access statistical data on migration ($p=0.022$), no statistically significant associations are observed between these variables.

The credibility attributed to social media platforms emerges as a relevant factor when considering the informational needs of Ecuadorian youth. The chi-square analysis reveals a significant association between the credibility attributed to X (SNC_X) and the need for information on statistical data and migration policies ($p=0.005$).

Likewise, the credibility attributed to YouTube (SNC_YouTube) is significantly associated with the need to understand migrants' life histories ($p=0.005$) and migration policies ($p=0.009$); the latter is also considerably associated ($p=0.019$) with the credibility attributed to Facebook (SNC_Facebook).

Figure 6 illustrates the distribution of responses across each category about the significant, albeit moderate, associations ($V<0.30$) identified through the

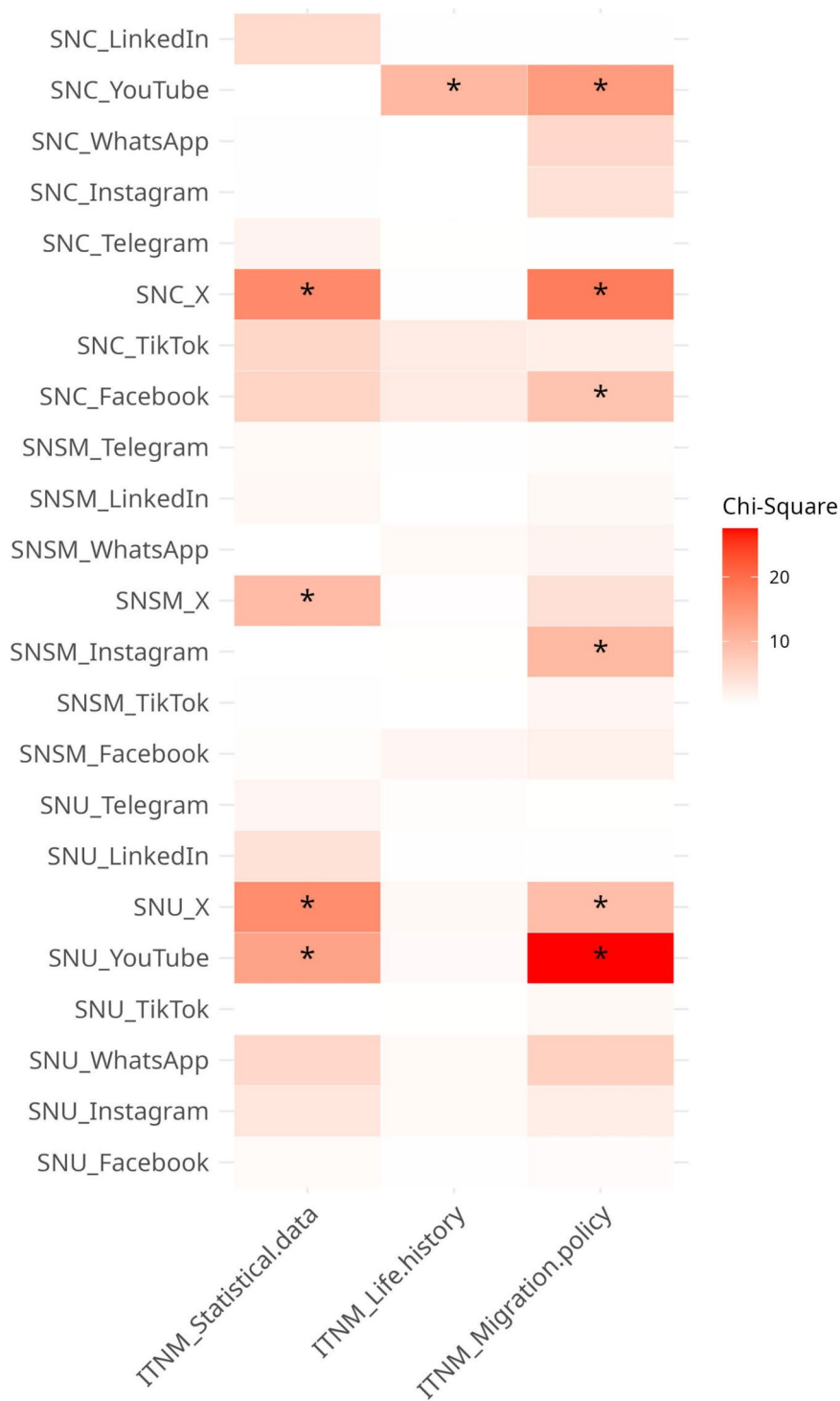
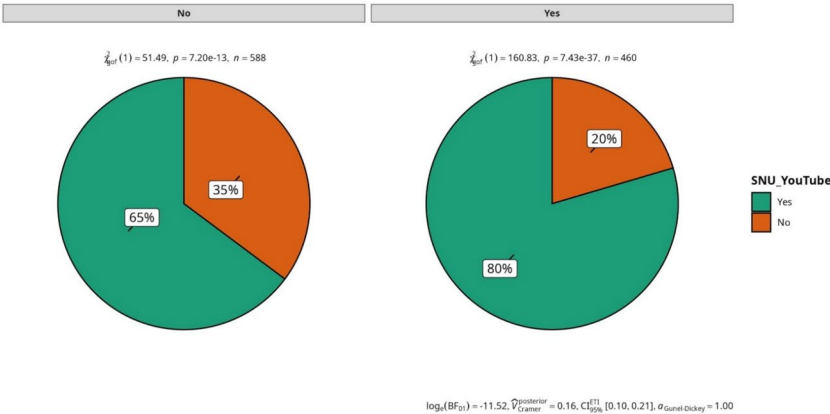


Figure 5. Relationship between information needs and the role of social networks in shaping perceptions of migration.

Note: ROLE OF SOCIAL NETWORKS. SNU_: social networks use+specific social network, SNSM_: social networks use for starting migration+specific social network, SNC_: social networks credibility+specific social network; ITNM_: information need+specific types of information.

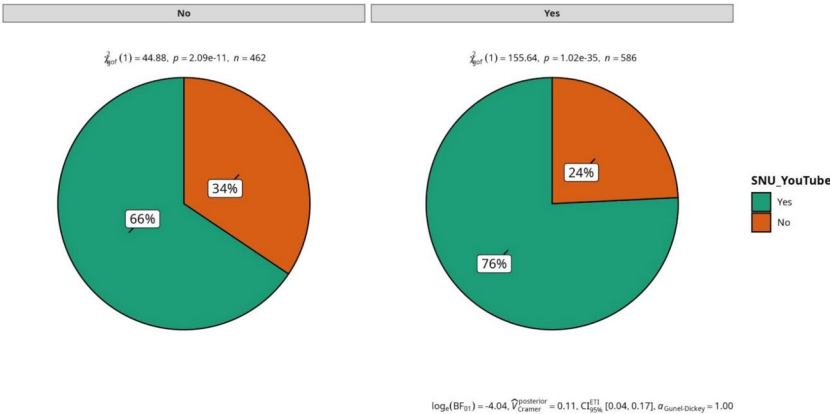
SNU_YouTube con ITNM_Migration.policy

$\hat{\chi}^2_{Pearson}(1) = 27.50, p = 1.57e-07, \hat{V}_{Cramer} = 0.16, CI_{95\%} [0.10, 0.22], n_{obs} = 1,048$



SNU_YouTube con ITNM_Statistical.data

$\hat{\chi}^2_{Pearson}(1) = 13.09, p = 2.98e-04, \hat{V}_{Cramer} = 0.11, CI_{95\%} [0.04, 0.17], n_{obs} = 1,048$



SNSM_Instagram con ITNM_Migration.policy

$\hat{\chi}^2_{Pearson}(1) = 9.81, p = 1.73e-03, \hat{V}_{Cramer} = 0.09, CI_{95\%} [0.02, 0.15], n_{obs} = 1,048$

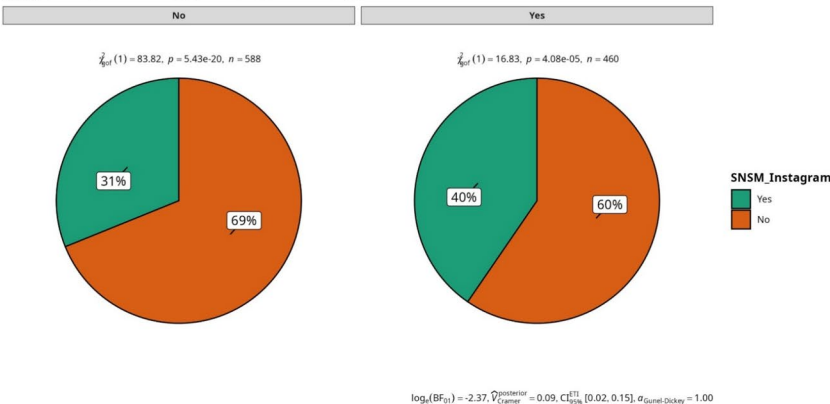


Figure 6. Strength of the relationship between types of social media use and migration-related information needs.
Note: ROLE OF SOCIAL NETWORKS. *SNU_YouTube*: social network use of YouTube, *SNSM_Instagram*: social network use of Instagram for starting migration; *ITNM_Migration.policy*: need for information on migration policy, *ITNM_Statistical.data*: need for information on statistical data.

chi-square analysis. These results provide the most relevant insights regarding the explanatory capacity of the collected data. Both young individuals who report using YouTube (80%) and those who do not (65%) predominantly express the need for more information on migration policies. This pattern is similarly observed, albeit with varying values, regarding the need for statistical data on migration. In the case of Instagram, the association is inversely proportional, as more than 60% of the surveyed youth consider this platform unsuitable for seeking information at the initial stage of the migration process, regardless of their specific informational needs.

The role of social media in shaping perceptions of the causes, challenges, and benefits of migration to another country

The primary drivers of migration among young people in Ecuador's Andean region are predominantly economic, specifically unemployment (83.9%) and wage disparities (78.8%). Additionally, a high crime rate (78.6%), internal conflict (56.1%), and the poor quality of education (68.1%) emerge as key social causes of migration. These are further compounded by corruption (76.3%) and political instability (80.4%), which are also perceived as sufficient reasons to migrate.

The study by Torres-Toukoumidis et al. (2024) highlights that the main perceived benefits of migration include improved economic conditions (67.7%), the ability to support one's family in the country of origin (69.6%), and access to educational and professional opportunities (65.5%). According to the authors, these benefits contrast with the challenges migrants often face, such as employment in positions not aligned with their professional qualifications (64.2%), loss of occupational status (62.7%), exhausting work schedules (66.5%), and the inability to reunite with family members left behind (59.98%).

A chi-square analysis reveals the relationships between these variables (Figure 7), showing that most statistically significant associations ($p < 0.05$) with the causes, challenges, and benefits of migration are linked to the group of variables concerning the adoption of different services (SNU_). Five social media platforms demonstrate statistically significant associations regarding perceived credibility. Meanwhile, the group of variables related to the type of social media used to initiate the migration process (SNSM_) shows weak associations only between Facebook ($p = 0.022$) and the improvement of migrants' economic conditions in the destination country (IEC), and between X ($p = 0.04$) and the high crime rate in the country of origin (HCR).

To facilitate the visualization of the chi-square analysis results presented in Figure 7, a matrix (Table 1) has been constructed that exclusively includes statistically significant associations among the

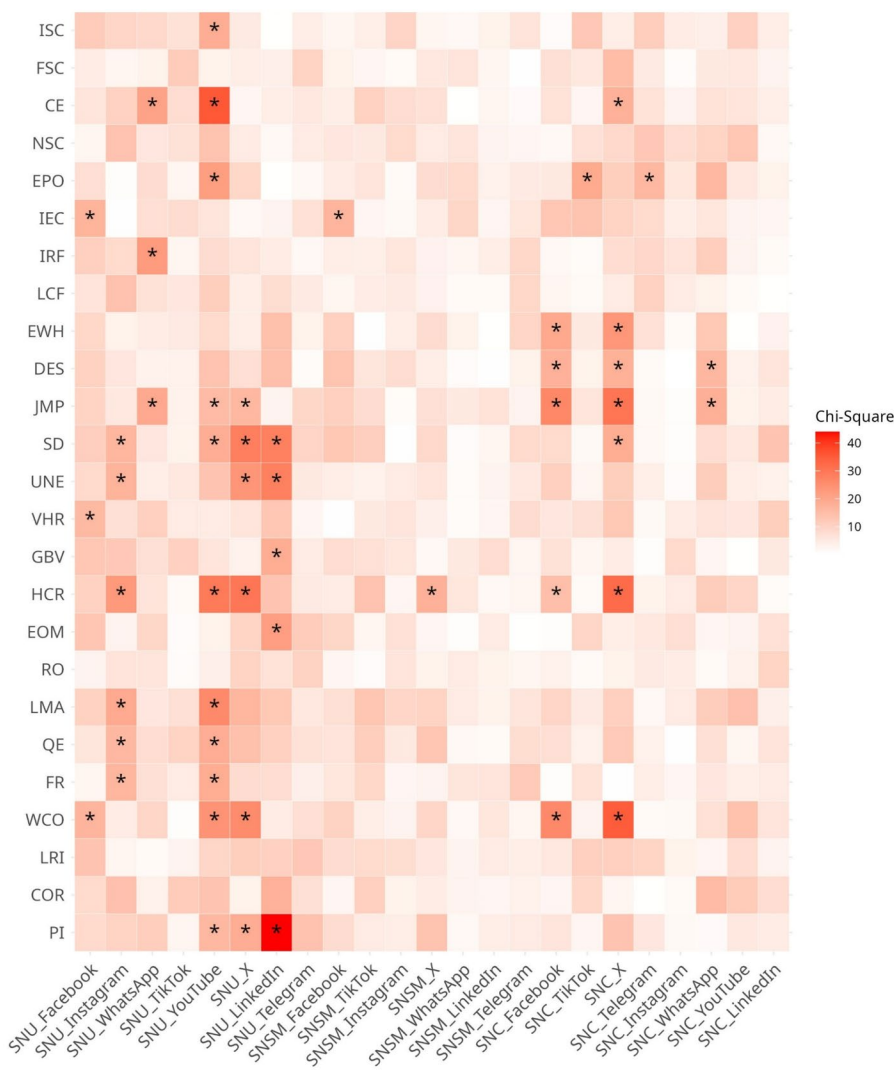


Figure 7. Heat map of relationship between role of social networks and causes, benefits and challenges of migration to another country.

Note: BENEFITS. ISC: Increased self-esteem and confidence, FSC: Family support in country of origin, CE: Cultural enrichment, NSC: New skills and competencies, EPO: Educational and professional opportunities, IEC: Improved economic conditions. CHALLENGES. IRF: Inability to reunite the family; LCF: Lack of communication with family at home, EWH: Exhausting working hours, DES: Decrease in employment status, JMP: Job mismatched to professional profile. CAUSES. SD: Salary differences, UNE: Unemployment, VHR: Violation of human rights, GBV: Gender-based violence, HCR: High crime rate, EOM: Exceptional openness to migrants from other countries, RO: Religious oppression, LMA: Lack of medical attention, QE: lack of quality in education, FR: Family regrouping, WCO: War conflicts, LRI: Lack of road infrastructure, COR: Corruption PI: Political instability. ROLE OF SOCIAL NETWORKS. SNU_: social network use+specific social network, SNSM_: social network use for starting migration+specific social network, SNC_: social network credibility+specific social networks.

variables under study. Variables related to the types of social media used at the onset of the migratory process have been excluded from this matrix due to the limited number of significant associations identified. This decision is supported by previously described results, where,

Table 1. Relationships between the role of social media and the benefits, challenges, and causes of migration to another country.

	SNU Facebook	SNU Instagram	SNU WApp	SNU YouTube	SNU X	SNU LinkedIn	SNC Facebook	SNC TikTok	SNC X	SNC Teleg.	SNC WApp
ISC	0.112	0.164	0.191	0.022*	0.496	0.988	0.946	0.076	0.558	0.125	0.644
CE	0.418	0.145	0.014*	0.014*	0.784	0.585	0.346	0.808	0.022*	0.346	0.346
EPO	0.295	0.962	0.255	0.022*	0.197	0.996	0.495	0.03*	0.132	0.04*	0.057
IEC	0.03*	0.984	0.280	0.394	0.843	0.739	0.083	0.070	0.164	0.239	0.418
IRF	0.130	0.226	0.014*	0.261	0.428	0.523	0.834	0.945	0.271	0.174	0.132
EWB	0.193	0.676	0.511	0.239	0.547	0.074	0.022*	0.482	0.014*	0.316	0.104
DES	0.141	0.429	0.668	0.083	0.295	0.074	0.03*	0.690	0.027*	0.880	0.014*
JMP	0.186	0.470	0.03*	0.036*	0.05*	0.745	0.014*	0.418	0.014*	0.874	0.027*
SD	0.132	0.045*	0.423	0.027*	0.014*	0.022*	0.216	0.859	0.036*	0.823	0.263
UNE	0.226	0.045*	0.547	0.081	0.014*	0.045*	0.132	0.762	0.133	0.605	0.132
VHR	0.043*	0.282	0.132	0.530	0.392	0.104	0.449	0.295	0.099	0.858	0.383
GBV	0.084	0.108	0.293	0.404	0.651	0.043*	0.349	0.776	0.524	0.949	0.819
HCR	0.145	0.027*	0.365	0.014*	0.014*	0.103	0.045*	0.896	0.014*	0.695	0.117
EOM	0.074	0.725	0.185	0.673	0.159	0.043*	0.949	0.174	0.547	0.466	0.802
LMA	0.148	0.014*	0.404	0.014*	0.057	0.097	0.162	0.504	0.129	0.825	0.124
QE	0.404	0.043*	0.268	0.04*	0.065	0.145	0.290	0.644	0.087	0.644	0.295
FR	0.759	0.014*	0.318	0.03*	0.249	0.239	0.946	0.346	0.991	0.574	0.452
WCO	0.03*	0.527	0.170	0.014*	0.014*	0.523	0.014*	0.723	0.014*	0.912	0.346
PI	0.216	0.174	0.152	0.027*	0.027*	0.014*	0.404	0.795	0.064	0.424	0.946

Level of significance: * $p_{adj} < 0.05$, ** $p_{adj} < 0.01$, and *** $p_{adj} < 0.001$; $n = 1.048$; $\alpha = 0.05$. BENEFITS. ISC: Increased self-esteem and confidence, CE: Cultural enrichment, EPO: Educational and professional opportunities, IEC: Improved economic conditions. CHALLENGES. IRF: Inability to reunite the family, EWB: Exhausting working hours, DES: Decrease in employment status, JMP: Job mismatched to professional profile. CAUSES. SD: Salary differences, UNE: Unemployment, VHR: Violation of human rights, GBV: Gender-based violence, HCR: High crime rate, EOM: Exceptional openness to migrants from other countries, LMA: Lack of medical attention, QE: lack of quality in education, FR: Family regrouping, WCO: War conflicts, PI: Political instability ROLE OF SOCIAL NETWORKS. SNU_: social networks use + specific social network, SNSM_: social networks use for starting migration + specific social network, SNC_: social networks credibility + specific social network.

despite some observed associations, consistent levels of statistical significance were not achieved. Applying the same criterion, three migration drivers (CO: Corruption; LRI: Lack of road infrastructure; RO: Religious oppression), one challenge (LCF: Lack of communication with family at home), and two benefits (FSC: Family support in country of origin; NSC: New skills and competencies) were also excluded from the matrix.

Among the variables, the use of YouTube by young people (SNU_Youtube) shows the highest number of statistically significant associations, particularly with six out of the fourteen identified drivers of migration to another country. Of these, five are social (HCR, LMA, QE, FR, and WR), and one is related to political instability in Ecuador (PI).

The use of Instagram is associated with six drivers of migration to another country, comprising two economic factors, unemployment and lack of economic opportunities (UNE) and wage differentials (SD), and four social factors like high crime rates (HCR), lack of access to basic services (LMA), quality of education (QE), and family reunification (FR). However, Instagram usage shows no statistically significant

associations with the challenges or benefits experienced by migrants in the host country.

LinkedIn use (SNU_LinkedIn) is likewise associated with four migration drivers and one challenge: the job mismatch problem (JMP). Nevertheless, the limited scope of this association renders the results potentially biased. X (formerly Twitter) usage (SNU_X) displays statistically significant associations with the challenge concerning the discrepancy between a migrant's professional qualifications and the employment obtained in the host country (JMP), as well as four migration drivers linked to wage differentials (SD), criminal violence (HCR), internal armed conflicts (WCO), and political instability (PI).

WhatsApp usage is significantly associated with two challenges: job mismatch problem (JMP) and inability to reunify with family (IRF), as well as one migration benefit: career enhancement (CE). In contrast, Facebook usage (SNU_Facebook) is not associated with migration challenges. Still, it is significantly associated with one migration benefit, improvement in the migrant's economic situation (IEC), and two social migration drivers: human rights violations (VHR) and internal armed conflicts (WCO).

Regarding the perceived credibility of social media, statistically significant associations are concentrated around specific variables within the sets of migration drivers, challenges, and benefits. The job mismatch problem (JMP) is the variable most frequently associated with the credibility attributed to social media platforms, particularly Facebook, X, and WhatsApp. Indeed, the challenges migrants face in the host country related to social media credibility pertain exclusively to employment-related issues and involve the same three platforms. Specifically, the decrease in employment status (DES) and exhausting working hours (EWH) exhibit significant associations with Facebook, X, and WhatsApp, respectively.

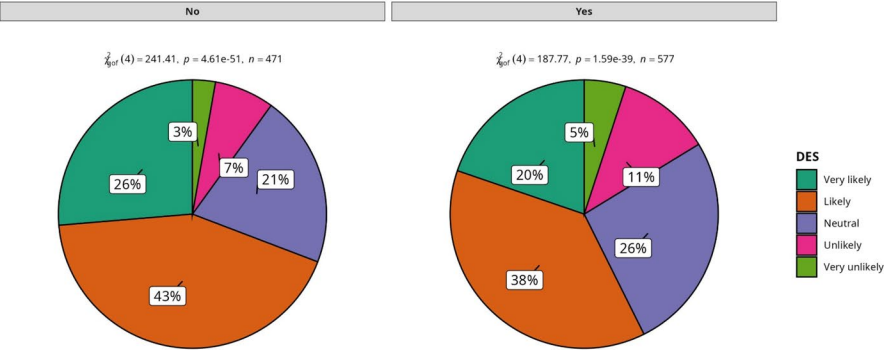
Finally, [Table 1](#) illustrates the presence of associations between educational and professional opportunities (EPO) in the destination country and the credibility (SNC_) attributed to TikTok and Telegram. At the same time, cultural enrichment (CE) is associated with the credibility attributed to X. Only three migration drivers are linked to the credibility attributed to X and Facebook, specifically, high crime rates (HCR) and war conflicts (WCO) about both platforms, and salary differentials (SD) exclusively in connection with X.

By employing pie charts ([Figure 8](#)), it becomes evident that perceptions regarding the decrease in employment status (DES) are influenced by the credibility attributed to social media platforms.

In particular, Facebook and WhatsApp exert an inversely proportional influence on young people's perceptions from the Andean region of

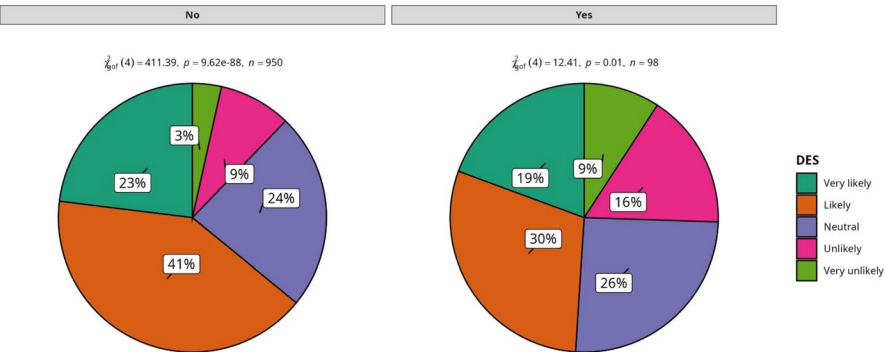
DES con SNC_Facebook

$\chi^2_{\text{Pearson}}(4) = 17.89, p = 1.30\text{e-}03, \hat{V}_{\text{Cramer}} = 0.12, \text{CI}_{95\%} [0.00, 0.17], n_{\text{obs}} = 1,048$



DES con SNC_WhatsApp

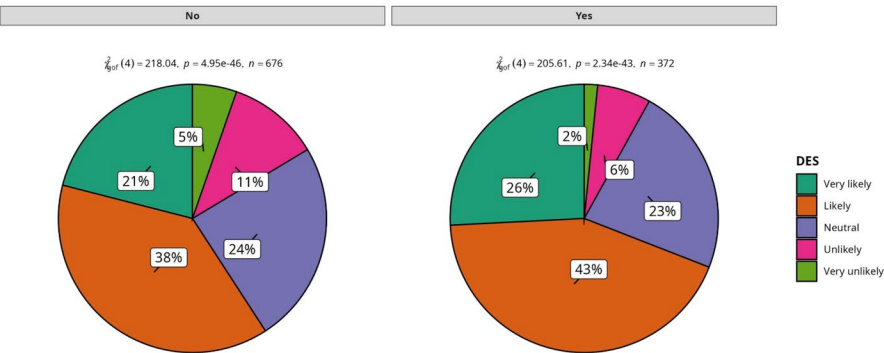
$\chi^2_{\text{Pearson}}(4) = 16.21, p = 2.75\text{e-}03, \hat{V}_{\text{Cramer}} = 0.11, \text{CI}_{95\%} [0.00, 0.16], n_{\text{obs}} = 1,048$



$\log_e(\text{BF}_{01}) = 3.14, \hat{V}_{\text{Cramer}}^{\text{posterior}} = 0.13, \text{CI}_{95\%}^{\text{ETI}} [0.05, 0.21], \sigma_{\text{Gunn-Dickey}} = 1.00$

DES con SNC_X

$\chi^2_{\text{Pearson}}(4) = 17.98, p = 1.25\text{e-}03, \hat{V}_{\text{Cramer}} = 0.12, \text{CI}_{95\%} [0.00, 0.17], n_{\text{obs}} = 1,048$



$\log_e(\text{BF}_{01}) = -0.88, \hat{V}_{\text{Cramer}}^{\text{posterior}} = 0.12, \text{CI}_{95\%}^{\text{ETI}} [0.06, 0.17], \sigma_{\text{Gunn-Dickey}} = 1.00$

Figure 8. Strength of the association between declining employment status and perceived credibility of Facebook, WhatsApp, and X.

Note: *DES*: Decrease in employment status; *SNC_Facebook*: credibility of Facebook, *SNC_WhatsApp*: credibility of WhatsApp, *SNC_X*: credibility of X.

Ecuador. Those who consider these platforms credible tend to view the likelihood of a migrant experiencing a decline in employment status in the host country as lower.

Conversely, the situation is reversed in the case of X. Individuals who attribute credibility to this platform are more likely to perceive a decline in migrants' employment status in the destination country than those who do not regard the information disseminated through X as credible.

Discussion

The findings of this study offer a nuanced understanding of how adolescents in Ecuador's Andean region interpret, negotiate and internalize migration through their everyday interactions with digital media. Rather than assuming a direct or deterministic relationship between media exposure and the formation of migratory imaginaries, the results reveal a multidimensional process in which social media platforms, credibility judgments and informational needs converge to shape how young people imagine the possibility of leaving the country. The data reflect not only the informational uses of digital platforms but also their symbolic and affective roles, revealing a set of interpretive practices that speak to broader questions about identity, aspiration and uncertainty in a context marked by economic fragility and social instability.

The evidence shows that adolescents clearly differentiate among platforms according to their communicative logics and perceived credibility. Although traditional media continue to hold symbolic authority for factual verification, social networks function as the primary arena where migration is narrated, imagined and emotionally processed. These platforms allow adolescents to see migration not only as a geopolitical issue but as a lived and shared experience articulated through personal testimonies, audiovisual storytelling and content circulated within peer groups. This aligns with research indicating that young people today inhabit hybrid informational ecosystems in which institutional communication coexists with personalized and experience driven narratives that foster identification and emotional engagement (Gómez-Vicario et al., 2024; Ihejirika & Krtalic, 2021). Within this environment, social media serve as a bridge between the structural and the intimate, offering adolescents a space where political, economic and cultural narratives intersect with personal and affective ones.

A striking finding is the robustness of the migratory imaginary among the surveyed youth. The overwhelming perception that migration is a current and tangible phenomenon, coupled with strong intentions to migrate, resonates with broader demographic and socio economic trends documented in Ecuador (Jokisch, 2023). Yet, the data also show that

adolescents' engagement with social networks does more than expose them to representations of migration; it fosters an interpretive environment in which these representations are compared, evaluated and recontextualised. Ninety percent of respondents affirm that their views are influenced by social media content. However, this influence is neither uniform nor uncritical. The minority of adolescents who do not perceive migration as a current phenomenon attribute greater weight to traditional media, suggesting that platform choice reflects deeper epistemological orientations toward information and reality. This reinforces the argument that adolescents exercise selective agency when navigating media landscapes, privileging certain sources over others depending on the type of information they seek and the degree of trust they assign to each platform.

The study's results also reveal important distinctions in how different platforms contribute to the construction of migration imaginaries. YouTube, in particular, emerges as a central space for meaning making. Its audiovisual and narrative formats amplify personal stories, day in the life content and documentary style accounts that speak to adolescents' preference for relatable and experiential narratives. Research has shown that storytelling formats resonate strongly with youth audiences because they allow individuals to understand complex social issues through concrete and emotionally charged examples (Pérez García & Sacaluga Rodríguez, 2023; Vieira & Munaro, 2019). Consistent with this, YouTube is significantly associated with several perceived causes and benefits of migration. This suggests that adolescents rely on the platform not only for information but as a symbolic space through which they make sense of the social motivations underlying migration and the imagined futures that migration might enable.

At the same time, the credibility attributed to YouTube does not appear to shape perceptions directly, which raises important questions about the distinction between the platform's affective and epistemic functions. Adolescents may trust YouTube for personal stories and testimonies while remaining cautious about its capacity to deliver policy specific or data driven information. This discrepancy reflects broader debates about the role of algorithmically curated content in exposing users to emotionally compelling but potentially decontextualized narratives (Chua et al., 2021). In this sense, the findings suggest that adolescents combine affective resonance with critical distance, a pattern aligned with arguments that contemporary media consumption among youth involves hybridized forms of engagement that are both emotional and analytical (Wang, 2021).

Another important contribution of this study lies in the identification of gendered patterns in social media use. Male adolescents demonstrate higher adoption and greater trust in platforms such as YouTube, X, Telegram and LinkedIn. These differences may reflect gender specific practices in the consumption and production of online content, including

higher exposure to certain informational genres, greater involvement in digital communities, or distinct orientations toward topics such as politics, migration or global opportunity. Although speculative, this finding invites further exploration of how gender mediates informational practices and vulnerability to certain narrative forms.

Geographical variations are equally noteworthy. Pichincha displays the highest diversity in platform adoption, suggesting that metropolitan environments may foster a more plural and exploratory engagement with digital media, while Azuay demonstrates a more critical stance toward certain platforms. These differences underscore the role of local social and cultural contexts in shaping adolescents' digital behaviors, reaffirming that media consumption is embedded in broader structural and community level dynamics.

Facebook, X and WhatsApp also play distinct roles in shaping migration related perceptions. Facebook emerges as a paradoxical platform: one of the most credible and useful for initiating migration processes, yet experiencing declining usage among young people (Jokisch, 2023). This indicates that credibility is not solely a function of popularity, but reflects the perceived seriousness, stability and institutional alignment of certain platforms. X is strongly associated with informational needs related to migration policies and statistical data, confirming its role as a platform oriented toward public discourse and high immediacy content (Citton, 2017). WhatsApp, despite its overwhelming adoption, displays low credibility, yet plays an important function in private, socially embedded communication that may include sensitive content about risks, informal routes and personal experiences. These findings highlight the functional segmentation through which adolescents navigate social networks, differentiating between platforms used for entertainment, interpersonal communication, information seeking or emotional support.

Importantly, the data show that not all platforms exert influence on migration imaginaries. Instagram and TikTok, despite being popular, do not contribute meaningfully to the construction of migration related perceptions. Their formats, which privilege aesthetic, fast paced and fragmentary content, may be incongruent with the type of information adolescents seek when reflecting on migration. This contrasts with findings in other contexts where these platforms have been shown to shape symbolic constructions of migration (Witteborn, 2020), suggesting that platform influence is contingent on the communicative needs, cultural contexts and informational expectations of specific populations.

The implications of this study are wide ranging. At a theoretical level, the findings affirm the relevance of Cultivation Theory and Framing Theory for understanding how adolescents interpret migration in digital environments. Yet the results also reveal that both frameworks must be

adapted to account for selective exposure, credibility evaluations and the affective intensity of social media narratives. Cultivation is no longer tied to prolonged exposure to homogeneous content, but emerges through fragmented, algorithmically filtered and emotionally charged interactions. Framing processes are similarly transformed, operating not only through journalistic practices but through user generated content, algorithmic amplification and interpersonal circulation.

At a practical level, the results underscore the need for media literacy interventions that move beyond fact checking or misinformation frameworks. Adolescents require tools to evaluate credibility, interpret narrative structures, recognize persuasive emotional cues and understand how algorithmic systems shape their exposure to migration related content. Strategies that work solely at the level of content verification will fall short if they do not address the symbolic and affective dimensions through which migration imaginaries are produced.

Finally, the study's insights are especially relevant for public policy in Ecuador. In a context where young people increasingly contemplate migration as a viable response to economic and social uncertainty, understanding how digital platforms shape these imaginaries is crucial. Public policies aimed at addressing youth migration must recognize that adolescents do not rely on a single source of information but interpret migration through a complex network of communicative influences that include institutional communication, peer interactions and algorithmic dynamics. Strengthening their interpretive capacity, rather than attempting to limit media exposure, may offer a more realistic and effective approach to supporting informed decision making.

Conclusions

The findings of this study confirm, with varying degrees of consistency, the initial hypotheses, contributing to a more precise understanding of social media platforms' role in shaping the migratory imaginary among young people in Andean regions of Ecuador. Overall, the evidence demonstrates that digital platforms, particularly YouTube, Facebook, X (formerly Twitter), and WhatsApp, function as significant spaces for symbolic and informational mediation, exerting differential influences on the perceptions, attitudes, and migratory intentions of youth in the provinces studied.

The data partially support the first hypothesis (H1), as significant associations were identified between media usage, particularly social media, and the construction of the migratory imaginary. Although traditional media maintain a degree of influence in shaping perceptions, their impact is comparatively limited when contrasted with social media's active role as symbolic reference environments. This is especially notable among youth

exhibiting a high intention to migrate. This difference in attributed influence suggests an ongoing shift in informational authority toward digital spaces, where audiovisual content, personal narratives, and transmedia discourses appear to carry greater weight in meaning-making processes.

The second hypothesis (H2) is also partially supported, with evidence indicating that the types of social media used and the perceived credibility of these platforms are related to the configuration of the migratory imaginary. However, this relationship is not uniform; only specific platforms (YouTube, Facebook, and X) show significant associations with variables concerning representations of migration's causes, benefits, and challenges. This selectivity suggests that not all social media platforms act as active agents in symbolic construction around migration. Some serve primarily entertainment or socialization functions, while others, as demonstrated, facilitate deeper cognitive engagement and meaning making.

The third hypothesis (H3) is fully supported. Specific informational needs, particularly regarding statistical data and migration policies, are significantly linked to the type of social media used and the credibility attributed to those platforms. The perceived informational utility of a social media platform depends not only on its adoption or popularity among young users but also on its perceived capacity to deliver verified, structured, and relevant content for migration-related decision-making. In this regard, the social network X emerges as a particularly salient channel for obtaining technical information. At the same time, platforms such as Instagram and TikTok, despite their high usage rates, are perceived as inadequate for such content, revealing an apparent functional dissonance.

The fourth hypothesis (H4) is likewise supported, as a significant relationship is established between using specific social media platforms, perceived credibility, and youth perceptions regarding migration's causes, challenges, and benefits. This link suggests a potential mediating function of digital platforms in forming social representations and allows for the identification of discursive patterns that vary by platform. YouTube stands out as the most influential channel, articulating multiple discourses reinforcing narratives concerning social motivations, developmental opportunities, and emotional challenges of migration processes. Meanwhile, X and Facebook foreground structural and sociopolitical causes of migration, whereas WhatsApp primarily functions as a channel for interpersonal communication, more closely associated with affective concerns or professional risks than structured informational processes.

A substantive contribution of this study lies in identifying a strategic and segmented media consumption pattern among young users. Not only do they differentiate between platforms based on perceived utility, but they also apply critical criteria to assess credibility, even within commonly used platforms, challenging the notion of a passive internalization of

migratory stereotypes (Dekker & Engbersen, 2014; Leurs & Smets, 2018). This selectivity reveals an advanced level of functional media literacy, whereby social media platforms are engaged according to the type of content sought, specific information, experiential narratives, or superficial socialization. Thus, digital platforms should not be interpreted as homogeneous spheres of influence but as differentiated interaction spaces, each with its own discursive logics and variable capacities for symbolic construction.

Finally, the results underscore that the influence of social media on the migratory imaginary, while significant, is neither totalizing nor a substitute for more stable sources of socialization such as family, community, or educational institutions. These continue to exert a structural influence on the formation of perceptions, values, and expectations, such that digital content is often reinterpreted through preexisting cultural frameworks. This interplay between media dynamics and structural contexts helps to explain why the migratory phenomenon, although widely recognized among youth, is represented in diverse ways depending on factors such as gender, geographical location, or individual information trajectories.

The robust empirical evidence presented in this study highlights social media's multifaceted role in shaping young people's migratory imaginations in Andean Latin American contexts. It offers new perspectives on the configuration of the digital ecosystem in which they are informed and socially engaged daily. The findings point to the need for deeper exploration of digital mediation mechanisms and media and information literacy processes, to design more effective and culturally relevant communication strategies to address migration as a complex, transnational, and multidimensional phenomenon.

Limitations and future research

Although the present study yields significant empirical insights, certain limitations must be acknowledged. Chief among these is the insufficient analytical distinction between variables related to collective perception and those associated with individual agency. This conceptual overlap may obscure a more refined understanding of how media exposure and social network interactions differentially influence shared representations versus personal migratory intentions. Future research should explicitly address this distinction to capture the mechanisms of symbolic mediation more accurately.

Another limitation is the lack of distinction between regular and irregular migration. While this choice is methodologically justified by the challenges of capturing legal status in school-based surveys, it restricts analyses to general perceptions. Future research should address this gap

by examining how migratory status shapes the imaginations, perceptions, and drivers of mobility among youth.

Additionally, the sample reflects a gender imbalance, with an over-representation of male respondents. This may correspond to gender-specific patterns of access to and engagement with social media platforms, influenced by distinct consumption behaviors, levels of media exposure, or degrees of media and information literacy. Subsequent studies should incorporate a gender-sensitive analytical framework to examine how these differences shape informational practices and migration-related imaginaries.

The study also highlights the contextual and culturally embedded nature of media preferences. Platform usage appears to be shaped not solely by functionality or popularity, but by broader structural and symbolic conditions. Consequently, future investigations should move beyond platform typologies to examine media content's discursive, narrative, and semiotic dimensions, particularly about platforms such as YouTube, which emerged as a key site of symbolic construction. In-depth qualitative analyses may reveal dominant framings, rhetorical strategies, and value systems that underlie migration discourses.

The perceived credibility of social media platforms is not necessarily aligned with the frequency of use. Instead, credibility appears contingent upon factors such as the authority, thematic focus, and perceived expertise of the content source variables that should be integrated into future explanatory and predictive models of digital mediation in migration contexts.

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Ethical approval statement

All procedures performed in studies involving human participants were in accordance with the ethical standards of the institutional and/or national research committee and with the 1964 Helsinki Declaration and its later amendments or comparable ethical standards. The study was evaluated and approved by the Dirección Distrital 01D02-PARROQUIAS URBANAS Y RURALES-EDUCACIÓN (Oficio Nro. MINDEDUC-CZ6-01D02-2023-08552-OF del

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Author contributions

Andrea De-Santis: Conceptualization, Methodology, Validation, Formal analysis, Investigation, Resources, Data Curation, Writing—Original Draft, Writing—Review & Editing, Visualization, Supervision, Project administration, Funding acquisition.
Ángel Torres-Toukoumidis: Conceptualization, Methodology, Validation, Resources, Writing—Original Draft, Writing—Review & Editing, Supervision.

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Data availability statement

The data that has been used is confidential and it will be made available on request.

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